Rani no Hajiro

What is Rani no Hajiro?

Rani no Hajiro is a historical place in the old city of Ahmedabad. It is the resting place of the queens from the time of the Gujarat Sultanate, built around the year 1445. The tombs are made of marble and have beautiful carvings, showing a mix of Hindu, Jain, and Islamic designs. Some families still live near the tombs and take care of them. It is a peaceful space with a strong connection to the past.

MARKET AROUND RANI NO HAJIRO

Right outside the tomb complex, there is a busy and colorful market. It is famous for selling women's clothes, jewelry, and Garba dresses during festivals. Many small stalls are set up, and you can also find mouth fresheners called Mukhwas. People from all over the city come here to shop, especially during festivals like Navratri. This market brings life to the area and helps keep the heritage of the place alive through everyday activity.

RESEARCH QUESTION

How does Rani no Hajiro market contribute to the cultural and historical identity of Old city (Ahmedabad), and how do social and economic factors impact its traditional essence and long-term viability?

THEMES

NOSTALGIA
Vendors and customers value the heritage and traditional shopping experience.

UNCERTAINITY
Vendors facing seasonal fluctuations and online competition.

FRUSTRATION
Infrastructure issues like flooding, congestion, and waste management affecting daily life.

DETERMINATION
Vendors and locals work hard to keep the market alive despite challenges.

CONNECTION
The market is more than just a place to shop; it brings people together.

Process

1. Site Visits
Returning to Rani no Hajiro across *[confirm: number]* visits to see how the market shifted by day, season and festival.

2. Vendor & Caretaker Interviews
Open conversations with *[confirm: number]* vendors and the families maintaining the tombs, over *[confirm: timeframe]*.

3. Observation
Watching everyday rhythms — who sets up where, what sells when, and how the space is shared between commerce and care.

4. Spatial Mapping
Recording stall positions and movement patterns against the tomb's own architecture.

5. Affinity Mapping & Personas
Clustering raw field notes into the five recurring themes and the personas that shaped the zine.

INSIGHTS AND OBSERVATIONS

Observations	Insights
They were concerned that we weren't students and that some of us were reporters who would alert the authorities because the location where they set up their stalls is illegal and the government has proposed two FIRs.	The family is anxious and distrustful of outsiders due to ongoing eviction threats. They rely on customers, but fear that media or official attention could lead to displacement showing how visibility in informal economies is both vital and risky.
Despite being a seasonal market, they operate their business full time since they depend on their devoted clients due to their generational ownership.	The market's generational ownership makes vendors rely on loyal customers, keeping it active year round. Stability matters more than expansion, as their inherited trade is their main livelihood. This shows how tradition and necessity shape their business choices.
The government is not helping in looking after the heritage as the caretakers have taken sole responsibility on themselves and they do not take stand for themselves as their house is demolished.	With their home demolished and family members sick, the caretakers have no choice but to stay. Leaving for other work means losing the only shelter they have the tomb they maintain. This highlights how heritage preservation for them is not a job but a means of survival.

OUTCOME

The final output of this project is a zine that translates our research on Rani no Hajiro into an accessible, visual narrative bringing together the personas, spatial mapping, and everyday rhythms of the place into a single tactile object.

WHY ZINE?

A zine let us present research in a way that's accessible and engaging, rather than locking it into a formal academic report.